

SoftwareX article template Version 6 (March 2026)

Before you complete this template, a few important points to note:

- This template is for an original *SoftwareX* article. If you are submitting an update to a software article that has already been published, please use the software update template from the Guide for Authors.
- **The format of a software article is very different to a traditional research article.** To help you write yours, we have created this template. **We will only consider software articles submitted using this template. Any submission that deviates widely will likely face desk rejection.**
- It is mandatory to **publicly share the code / software** referred to in your software article. You'll find information on our software sharing criteria in the *SoftwareX* [Guide for Authors](#).
- It's important to consult the [Guide for Authors](#) when preparing your manuscript; it highlights mandatory requirements and is packed with useful advice. Here are some key ones (**please read**):
 - We only accept GitHub repositories within Metadata Tables. This is required for forking to our SoftwareX repository if your paper is published. We are unable to accept other repositories.
 - GitHub repositories must have a well-documented README.md file, and a Licence.txt file. Your paper will be returned if these are missing.
 - Our word limit is 4,000 words. Please focus your paper on the software and place supporting information into your GitHub repository README.md file.
 - Limit figures to a maximum of six (6) and sparingly include any further display media.
 - We require the five (5) main templated sections outlined below. Your paper will be returned or rejected if these are missing.

If you have any remaining questions, please email our editorial team at softwarex@elsevier.com.

Now you are ready to fill in the template below. As you complete each section, please carefully read the associated instructions. **All sections are mandatory**, unless marked *optional*.

Once you have completed the template, delete this line and everything above it before submitting your article. In addition, please delete the instructions in the template (the text written in italics).

Title (Name of your software: The a SHORT title)

Names of authors / main developers (incl. affiliations, addresses, email)

Abstract

(ca. 100 words)

Your main body of text (Sections 1-5 below) should be a maximum six (6) pages in total (excluding metadata, tables, figures, references) with a 4000-word limit (we ask that more priority is placed on the word limit versus the page count). Though we strictly insist on the author following the template, in exceptional circumstances, we can be flexible with the page numbers and word limit. In such cases, it should be discussed with the Managing Editor or publisher prior to submission. All queries regarding the same can be reached at softwarex@elsevier.com.

Keywords

(maximum of six)

Metadata

This ancillary data table is required for your submission. Please replace the italicized text in the right column with the correct information about your current code and leave the left column untouched.

Nr	Code metadata description	Metadata
C1	Current code version	<i>For example: v42</i>
C2	Permanent link to code/repository used for this code version	<i>For example: https://github.com/mozart/mozart2. Please note that a GitHub repository is mandatory. We will not proceed with your paper otherwise.</i>
C3	Legal code license	<i>All software and code must be released under one of the pre-approved licenses listed in the Guide for Authors, such as Apache License, GNU General Public License (GPL) or MIT License. Write the name of the license you've chosen here.</i>
C4	Code versioning system used	<i>For example: svn, git, mercurial, etc. (put 'none' if none used)</i>
C5	Software code languages, tools and services used	<i>For example: C++, python, r, MPI, OpenCL, etc.</i>

C6	Compilation requirements, operating environments and dependencies	
C7	If available, link to developer documentation/manual	For example: http://mozart.github.io/documentation/
C8	Support email for questions	

1. Motivation and significance

In this section, we want you to introduce the scientific background and the motivation for developing the software.

- *Explain why the software is important and describe the exact (scientific) problem(s) it solves.*
- *Indicate in what way the software has contributed (or will contribute in the future) to the process of scientific discovery; if available, please cite a research paper using the software.*
- *Provide a description of the experimental setting. (How does the user use the software?)*
- *Introduce related work in literature (cite or list algorithms used, other software etc.).*

2. Software description

Describe the software. Provide enough detail to help the reader understand its impact.

2.1. Software architecture:

Give a short overview of the overall software architecture; provide a pictorial overview where possible; for example, an image showing the components. If necessary, provide implementation details.

2.2. Software functionalities:

Present the major functionalities of the software.

2.3. Sample code snippets analysis (optional).

3. Illustrative examples

Provide at least one illustrative example to demonstrate the major functions of your software/code.

OPTIONAL: you may include one explanatory video or screencast that will appear next to your article, in the right-hand side panel. Please upload any video as a single supplementary file with your article. Only one MP4 formatted, with 150MB maximum size, video is possible per article. Recommended video dimensions are 640 x 480 at a maximum of 30 frames / second. Prior to submission please test and validate your .mp4 file at <http://elsevier->

apps.sciverse.com/GadgetVideoPodcastPlayerWeb/verification} . This tool will display your video exactly in the same way as it will appear on ScienceDirect.

4. Impact

This is the main section of the article and reviewers will weight it appropriately. Please indicate:

- *Any new research questions that can be pursued as a result of your software.*
- *In what way, and to what extent, your software improves the pursuit of existing research questions.*
- *Any ways in which your software has changed the daily practice of its users.*
- *How widespread the use of the software is within and outside the intended user group (downloads, number of users if your software is a service, citable publications, etc).*
- *How the software is being used in commercial settings and/or how it has led to the creation of spin-off companies.*

Please note that points 1 and 2 are best demonstrated by references to citable publications.

5. Conclusions

This is a mandatory section summarising your software based on the sections above.

Acknowledgements

Optional. You can use this section to acknowledge colleagues who don't qualify as a co-author but helped you in some way.

References

*[1] Use this style of ordering. **References in-text must also use this style.***

If the software repository you used supplied a DOI or another Persistent Identifier (PID), please add a reference for your software here. For more guidance on software citation, please see our guide for authors or this [article on the essentials of software citation](#) by FORCE 11, of which Elsevier is a member.

Reminder: Before you submit, please delete all the instructions in this document (the text in italics), including this paragraph.

Thank you!